



Interpreting Guidelines and Procedures (2025 Edition)

The 2025 edition of the Interpreting Guidelines and Procedures reflects client feedback, Service Observation results, training procedures, culturally and linguistically appropriate services in healthcare, industry-specific standards, and industry standards as defined by the National Council on Interpreting in Health Care (NCIHC). It should also be noted that this document reflects inclusive language in our efforts to remain culturally sensitive and culturally responsive to the needs of the LGBTQ+ community. LanguageLine Solutions embraces diversity in all of its forms; as such, the use of preferred pronouns for clients, interpreters, and the **Individuals with Limited English Proficiency (Individuals with LEP)** is essential. You should become acquainted and comfortable with the use of pronouns, including gender-neutral pronouns, to make sure you avoid misgendering anyone on any call you handle; we must treat everyone with the respect they deserve. To set a standard of excellence for customer service as the leader in the language service industry, we must understand that language, expression and ways of communication evolve over time; by respecting preferred forms of address and preferred pronouns in our interactions with all parties on the line, we can avoid doing a disservice to the individual who is expecting to be treated fairly. As interpreters, you should follow the client's lead or the lead of the individual with LEP and not make any assumptions. Making assumptions can result in mistakes that can be offensive. Creating a healthy environment where everyone is appreciated based on their uniqueness and identity is essential.

All interpreters, including employees, independent contractors and vendors/Affiliate Partners, are expected to comply with all the call-handling procedures herein.

Accuracy in renditions and quality in customer service continue to be the ideal combination to ensure total and complete client satisfaction. The Guidelines and Procedures have been revised to help you, as a professional interpreter, to continue to reinforce the principle of providing excellent customer service and a superior quality of interpretation.

LanguageLine Solutions upholds the importance of cultural competence, particularly when handling healthcare-related calls. Applying cultural knowledge in supporting the individual with LEP to ensure we properly communicate their cultural practices is not only good customer service but also an industry requirement.

As always, not every possible call situation can be described in the Interpreting Guidelines. This is why we continue to rely on your best judgment, as a professional interpreter, to handle unforeseen situations to the best of your ability. Additionally, you should rely on the feedback that your Senior Language Specialist SM (SLS SM) provides to ensure that all standards are being met. You are furthermore encouraged to uphold the concept of total and complete client satisfaction while still continuing to adhere to the Interpreter Code of Ethics as the number one reference source for practicing the art of interpretation.

The LanguageLine Solutions Interpreting Guidelines and Procedures policy is a living document; as such, it is subject to future revisions at the company's discretion for the purpose of continuing to meet the needs of our clients, the community of individuals with LEP and Deaf or Hard of Hearing community, and the profession.

~LLS Quality Assurance Department

Previous editions: 1995, 1998, 2000, 2002, 2003, 2004, 2006, 2011, 2012, 2013, 2014, 2016, 2017, 2021, 2022, and 2025.

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1. Introduction

The Guidelines and Procedures have been developed as a result of a joint effort between the Training and Quality Assurance departments at LanguageLine Solutions. We take pride in knowing that our solid experience in the industry has made us the leader of Over-the-Phone (OPI) and Video Remote Interpreting (VRI). Additionally, we have benchmarked the interpreting standard that is accepted both nationally and internationally. Our Guidelines reflect the requirements of our clients as well as the professional practices and ethics of interpreters worldwide. This document reflects our commitment to our profession, which includes the highest level of customer service and interpreting skills.

Our mission as professional interpreters is to be the bridge between our clients and their customers; i.e., the community of individuals with LEP and Deaf or Hard of Hearing community, and to allow them to communicate effectively on every call. We build bridges by which, for example, a nurse can explain to a diabetic patient how to take his medication, a mother can select medical benefits for her family, a customer can get a replacement for a defective product, and a resident of a disaster-declared area can receive assistance from the government, just to name a few scenarios. The objective is to convey all messages with accuracy, neutrality, empathy, compassion, and respect. In order to help build that bridge, the Guidelines document has been revised to enable you, the interpreter, to maintain and consistently deliver, the highest standards that LanguageLine Solutions has pledged to provide. As you become familiar with the Interpreting Guidelines, you will find that this document delineates the following:

The rules of customer service that are crucial to each communication: i.e., the proper opening and closing of a call, what to do if one party becomes upset, how to effectively deliver the message, how to handle challenging situations, how to manage the call efficiently, how to be helpful while staying within your role, etc.

The principal tenets that you should abide by when interpreting: i.e., accuracy of the intended meaning, completeness of the rendition, staying in the interpreter's role, impartiality, timeliness of renditions, proper management of call flow, securing a quiet background and a suitable workspace, etc.

The methods and procedures that you need to follow to manage the call efficiently: i.e., requesting repetition or clarification, verifying information, keeping the client informed, maintaining neutrality, following the client's lead, etc.

The various protocols that govern the communications with our clients who have specific requirements: for example, effective management of emergency calls, cultural brokering when applicable, the use of special scripts provided by clients, etc.

The Interpreting Guidelines provide direction and help you navigate challenging situations by providing clarity on best practices that should be adhered to, and also provide you with examples drawn from the experience of fellow senior interpreters, who are also highly qualified certified coaches; i.e., the Senior Language Specialists. Adhering to all rules will help you succeed in your job without having to guess how to approach an issue or challenge. This document is intended to provide the guiding principle for all aspects of your work, while still enabling you to exercise your best judgment in dealing with unique situations. We expect you to review this document and keep it readily available to use as a guide to secure a successful interpreting session in each encounter.

2. Customer Service Skills

In order to maintain our position at the forefront of the industry, our interpreters must provide the most professional customer service to our clients at all times, which encompasses courtesy as well as accuracy. We operate on the principle that “the customer is always right,” which suggests that you should always respect the client’s request and not become defensive. We will always put the client’s needs first and be responsive, caring and respectful at all times. While accuracy is one of the most highly valued aspects of your performance, professionalism, cultural awareness, compassion, and customer service are equally important. The following section touches upon different aspects of customer service.

2.1 Open the Call Appropriately

Initiating the call properly by adhering to the following guidelines sets the tone for the rest of the interpreting session.

2.1.1 Answer the Phone Appropriately

In order to minimize the connect time, you should answer the phone promptly on all calls (OPI and VRI) as illustrated in the following example: *“Thank you for calling. This is Maria, Interpreter ID 555555 for Spanish. I am proud to serve you. This call may be monitored for Training and Quality Assurance purposes. Is your customer with you or do you need me to call them for you?”* Unacceptable openings of calls are, for example, *“Maria here”* or *“Hullo?”*

NOTE: Keep in mind that the Monitoring/Opening Statement disclosure - “This call may be monitored for Training and Quality Assurance purposes” - should not be stated when specific instructions in the system prompt you to not include it in your greeting to some clients : the alert will be via a whisper prompt, audible tone or visual cue.

You are expected to provide your first name upon answering the phone according to the way your name is registered with LanguageLine Solutions; using a different name is not acceptable. If you prefer to use a nickname to ensure that the client can easily pronounce your name, you may use a registered nickname; it is recommended that you update your nickname with LanguageLine Solutions to ensure it is listed in your interpreter profile.

During your shift or when you log in, you should answer the phone personally at all times. In addition, to ensure confidentiality and the best possible sound quality, speakerphones, cordless/wireless phones and/or cordless/wireless headsets are not allowed.

2.1.2 Appropriately Greet the Client/Agent/Individual with LEP (and Dial-Out)

- **Greeting the Client/Dial-Out**

Once again, you should greet the client as soon you answer the call and identify yourself as illustrated in the following examples:

“This is Marcos, Interpreter ID 555555, for Spanish. I am proud to serve you. This call may be monitored for Training and Quality Assurance purposes. Is your customer with you or do you need me to call them for you?”

When applicable, ask the client: *“If we get a voicemail, would you like to leave a message?”*, and then follow the client’s instructions. If the client would like to leave a voicemail, gather the detailed message prior to placing the dial-out.

NOTE: Please refer to the User manuals for instructions on conferencing parties.

- Some useful phrases that should be used **by all interpreters** to enhance customer service with a dial-out request are, *“Certainly. What is the number you would like me to dial, please, beginning with the area code?”* or *“Whom should we ask for?”* or *“How would you like me to introduce you?”* or *“If we get a voicemail, would you like me to leave a message?”* Or, if the number is busy, you should say, *“Is there an alternate number you would like me to dial for you?”*

- **If the client states that a dial-out is not needed**, please add, “*I am ready for your instructions,*” and proceed with the call as usual. Once the individual with LEP is on the line, greet them, as culturally appropriate, and identify yourself as the interpreter. You may provide your first name to the individual with LEP if it is culturally appropriate; otherwise, you do not need to provide your first name as it may cause confusion. Proceed with the call as usual.

- **Request for Multiple Dial-Outs**

You may place multiple dial outs as needed. Please follow user manual instructions to complete a dial-out.

- **Using the Client’s Name**

When provided, you should use the client’s name often, as this is an expression of excellent customer service. If the client does not provide their name during the greeting, and you feel that it is important to know the name in order to better handle the call flow, you may politely request the name of the client. Another option would be to use some other polite form of address, or the client’s preferred form of address, such as “Doctor”, their first name, their last name, etc. It is also acceptable to address the client by their preferred name throughout the call. An appropriate way to obtain the client’s name (if not provided) is by saying, “*How may I address you?*”, “*How may I introduce you?*”, or “*How would you like me to introduce you to your caller?*”

- **Greeting Co-workers/Agents**

Internal customer service is as important as the customer service offered to external parties, i.e., the clients. The call begins once the interpreter answers the phone. When in need to transfer the call to a Customer Agent (CA), for example, both the CA and the interpreter should be courteous and polite. Informal greetings should be avoided. Both co-workers should abstain from using nicknames and/or terms of endearment to address each other.

- **Greeting the Individual with Limited English Proficiency (LEP)**

In the target language, you should offer a clear and friendly greeting to the individual with LEP, identify yourself as the interpreter, and state (**in the target language**), “*Hello, I will be your interpreter. I am proud to serve you. This call may be monitored for Training and Quality Assurance purposes.*” Then follow the client’s instructions. NOTE: “*This call may be monitored for Training and Quality Assurance purposes*” should not be stated when indicated by the system via a whisper prompt, audible tone or visual cue. Some examples of appropriate introductions, based on instructions provided by the client, are: “*Hello, I’m the interpreter today for you and Ifrah from _____ (company name); I am proud to serve you. May I have your account number?*” or “*Hello, I’m your interpreter and I have Michael on the line. I am proud to serve you. May I have your credit card number?*” or, “*Hello, I am the interpreter. I am proud to serve you. We have the representative, Letty, from _____ (company name) on the line. How may we help you?*” If the client does not provide any instructions, you should make sure to address the client as follows: “*I am ready for your instructions*” and/or, “*How may I introduce you?*”

NOTE: “I am proud to serve you” must be rendered in the target language in its equivalent interpretation taking into account linguistic and cultural differences/nuances while maintaining the similar sentiment.

It is important to use the most respectful form of address when speaking to the Individual with LEP, particularly if they are elderly. Follow cultural practices/language-specific nuances and demonstrate the expected level of courtesy and professionalism to ensure you are being culturally appropriate/sensitive.

Although you are not expected to provide your name to the individual with LEP, it may be appropriate, for cultural reasons, to offer your first name to them. Please apply what is most appropriate according to the culture of the individual with LEP for whom you are interpreting.

It is inappropriate and unacceptable to read out to the individual with LEP the name of the organization as it appears on the screen. When in doubt, you should ask the client whether the name of their organization should be announced in your greeting to the individual with LEP.

2.1.3 When the Individual with LEP is the only Party on the Line

You should politely and promptly inform the individual with LEP that the English-speaking representative is not on the line, and ask them to call back the original number. If necessary, briefly explain that they have reached an interpreting service.

The only exception is the call flow for Direct Response calls -These are calls where the individual with LEP will need your direct assistance to be connected to the client. You should, therefore, answer the phone in language to greet the individual with LEP. Please follow the system instructions/whisper prompt. An example of a Direct Response whisper prompt is as follows:

“Interpreter, please answer the call in Spanish, and collect the name of the caller (individual with LEP). You and the caller will be automatically redirected to a representative shortly.”

Your greeting to the individual who has LEP should be as follows:

(in language) *“Hello, I will be your Spanish interpreter. May I please have your name? Thank you. One moment while we are connected to a representative.”*

2.2 Follow the Client’s Instructions

You must follow the client’s instructions **at all times**. Conversely, you must never take the initiative to provide any instructions to the client or the individual with LEP. It is recommended, however, that you make courteous and respectful requests of the client in challenging scenarios, such as when needing repetition or clarification or when attempting to overcome audibility issues that are beyond your control. For example, *“This is the interpreter. Would you mind if I ask Ms. Solano to speak louder/turn the radio down?”*

2.2.1 Initial Instructions from Client

You should follow the client’s instructions throughout the call, especially at the beginning of the call when the client begins to provide you with specific instructions. You are expected to follow all instructions to the letter and render the instructions to the individual with LEP as indicated by the client. Examples of initial instructions provided by the client based on their own disclosure, and which should be followed to the letter when addressing the individual with LEP, are: *“This call may be **monitored or recorded** for Quality Assurance and Training purposes,”* or *“Please thank Mrs. Loi for calling,”* or *“Please let Mr. Quesada know I am a customer service representative from XYZ.”*

When the client provides a string of instructions to you, such as *“Please get their name, home phone number, work phone number, address, date of birth, and the reason for their call,”* you may proceed to obtain two or three pieces of information at a time and relay these to the client in a timely manner. Once this is done, you should proceed to obtain the rest of the information. This will avoid giving the impression of having a personal conversation with the individual with LEP since you will most likely have to request repetition/clarification on numbers/addresses. In the event of having to request repetition/clarification, please keep in mind that you should keep the client abreast of all interactions at all times.

2.2.2 Lack of Initial Instructions from Client

Most clients will have specific instructions for you, but when the client does not provide specific instructions and merely says, “*Go ahead, Interpreter,*” you may politely initiate the call by saying to the individual with LEP, in-language, “*Hello, I will be the interpreter for this call. I am proud to serve you. How may I help you?*”, or make sure to address the English-speaking client as soon as you can by saying, “*I am ready for your instructions*” and/or ask, “*How may I introduce you?*”

2.2.3 When the Client Wishes to Place the Call on Hold

When a client asks if the call can be placed on hold, you must interpret this question to the individual with LEP, rather than replying directly. Once the individual with LEP agrees to hold, please interpret the response to the client and follow the client’s lead.

Please also follow the client’s lead as to how long to remain on hold. Some calls require a longer wait time, such as when the calls are transferred internally or when the client looks for additional information. There might be occasions when the client, for some unknown reason, doesn’t come back to the line. Generally speaking, **once you have been on hold with the individual with LEP for 15 minutes, unless specifically instructed to wait for a longer period of time** by the client, you should recommend that the individual with LEP hang up and call the client back. While on hold, you should reassure the individual with LEP (every 30-45 seconds or so) that you continue on hold. Not reassuring the individual with LEP, while both of you are on hold, is unacceptable.

Please note you may see on your screen specific hold-time instructions in the ALERT NOTES field of the organization based on client-specific requirements. Please follow those instructions/requirements to the letter, as applicable.

When the individual with LEP and client are face to face, you should be on hold as long as the client requires you to do so and reassure the individual with LEP every 5 minutes or so. Should you have to disconnect from the call before the client returns to the line, a Report Call Problem should be submitted.

2.2.4 When Interpreter’s Services are No Longer Needed

When the client indicates that your services are no longer needed, you should follow the client’s instructions and release the call after a brief closing. For example, Client: “*Thank you, Interpreter. I’ll take it from here.*” Interpreter: “*Certainly, Ms. Georges. I’ll let your caller know that I will be disconnecting from the call.*” To the individual with LEP, in-language: “*Mrs. González, I will now be disconnecting. Please remain on the line. Have a great day.*”

NOTE: It is unacceptable to remain on the line when the client decides to talk to the individual with LEP directly, or transfers the individual with LEP to another department, or in any other scenario where you have been instructed to release the line. LanguageLine Solutions adheres to the Compliance Policy intended to prevent, detect and report (as necessary) violations of Fraud, Waste, and Abuse laws; the objective is to create an environment in which LanguageLine Solutions employees, contractors and vendors conduct their daily activities in compliance with applicable laws.

2.3 Use Polite Forms of Expression/Appropriate Tone /Courtesy to the Client and Individual with LEP

You should use proper forms of address at all times, using an appropriate title (*Dr. Comellas, Your Honor, Mr. Delgado, Mrs. Rivera, etc.*) or addressing the client or individual who has LEP by their name, with or without a title, according to the relevant cultural standards. Polite forms of expression toward the individual with LEP may vary from culture to culture; as such, you are advised to use the most polite form of address. For example, in Vietnamese culture, it is customary to address an elderly gentleman as “*Grandpa.*” Also, if your language has both formal and informal means of addressing the individual with LEP, choose the one

that is formal and demonstrates the highest degree of respect. For example, for a Spanish interpreter, it is expected and culturally appropriate to use “*Usted*,” not “*Tú*,” when speaking to the individual with LEP.

A good tone of voice is the primary tool for providing outstanding customer service and it allows interpreters to establish a strong positive rapport with clients. You should, therefore, maintain a warm, pleasant, and professional tone of voice when interacting with the client. When interacting with the individual who has LEP, you should also use a tone that is respectful and appropriate to his or her culture. In over-the-phone interpreting, as well as video interpreting, the tone of voice used by the interpreter is the most important means of communicating the pleasure with which the interpreter is doing their job.

In addition, your voice volume needs to be at a level to be heard comfortably by both parties on the line. You should make every effort to try to resolve problems related to volume. If the client or individual with LEP cannot hear you, you should explain to them what you will do to try to remedy the situation, i.e., try to raise your voice volume (yelling is inappropriate) or adjust the volume on the equipment. On all calls, you are expected to care for the client by using words and phrases such as, “*please*,” “*thank you*,” “*I apologize*,” “*excuse me*,” “*certainly*,” etc.

In the event of a problem on the call, and regardless of any responsibility you may or may not have had for the problem, it is important to acknowledge the client’s comments. For example, “*I understand your concern. I am very sorry that happened*,” “*I regret the inconvenience*,” “*Thank you for your understanding*,” or “*Excuse me, Dr. Rojas, it appears the system is not working*.” **Never become defensive.**

It is crucial that all polite forms/pleasantries used by the client or Individual with LEP be rendered as well.

For legal calls, particularly court calls, however, it is inappropriate to add pleasantries that are not expressed by any of the parties involved; you should stay in the role of conduit.

One of the most important tasks of an interpreter is to request clarifications to ensure the accuracy and completeness of the information they are interpreting. Additionally, clarifications may be used to resolve obstacles to communication and to alert the client of unusual circumstances during the interpreting session. It is very important that you obtain clarification from all parties with the utmost respect, courtesy and professionalism. For example, it is appropriate to say, “*I’m sorry, but the interpreter requests an explanation of Digital Tomosynthesis*”, or “*I’m sorry, this is the interpreter, Dr. Ramirez; please allow me a minute to verify a term with Mrs. Bustos*” or “*This is the interpreter, Mr. Vargas, would you please explain the term ‘home preservation’?*” Never use phrases such as, “*What did you say?*”, “*What was that?*”, “*Say that again*,” “*Come again?*” or “*I didn’t catch that*.”

Formal, polite and complete utterances are to be used when responding to clients’ questions; such phrases include, “*Yes, I’ll be happy to*” and “*My pleasure*,” instead of, “*Yeah, no problem*.” Use phrases, such as “*I’m sorry, I don’t know, but I’ll find out for you, Ms. Perez*” instead of saying, “*I’m not sure*” or “*Uh, no*.” Also, make sure to enunciate clearly and avoid incomplete and informally pronounced expressions as, “*I dunno*,” “*Yep*,” “*Nope*” and “*Yeah*”, etc. Verbal acknowledgements of clients’ requests or instructions are also appropriate, such as “*I understand*,” “*Sure, of course*,” “*Absolutely*,” etc. Verbal acknowledgements should be uttered in a professional and polite tone of voice.

It is important to you use the mute button in the following instances: when you cough, sneeze, hiccup, or clear your throat. In the event that you do not have the time to do so, please excuse yourself with a, “*I’m sorry*” or “*Excuse me*.” Please note that audible yawning and/or sighing on the line are unacceptable behaviors.

2.4 Demonstrate Patience /Helpfulness and Use Attentive Listening

You must remain patient and maintain composure throughout the call despite the presence of any adverse situation, such as difficulty hearing either party or dealing with a frustrated client or individual with LEP.

The use of foul language/expletives before, during, or after a call, as well as in-between calls, is unacceptable. Any use of profanities at any given time in the workplace is extremely unprofessional and inappropriate, and is, therefore, cause for immediate dismissal.

If, for whatever reason, a client becomes noticeably upset with the interpreting service, you should remain patient, and courteously acknowledge the concerns of the client by saying, for example, *“I do understand your concern, Madeline”* or *“I apologize for this experience, Leonardo.”* The interpreter should then offer to pass the information on to the appropriate department. You should also submit a Support Request (SR). **Never become defensive or argumentative with the client or individual with LEP.**

Oftentimes, a client may be using our services for the first time, in which case you are encouraged to be helpful and briefly advise the client on how the interpreting session works. Should the client say, *“I’ve never used this service before; what should I do? Should I transfer the customer to you?”* you should reply by saying, *“I’ll be more than happy to help you, Melanie. Please remain on the line and conference in your caller. Once all three of us are on the line, I will proceed to interpret for both of you. Please let me know if there’s anything in particular you would like me to say to your customer.”*

On customer service types of calls, an extra degree of helpfulness may be required to further facilitate the communication process. This should be done by keeping the client in the loop at all times to ensure that the client knows you are not taking over the call. Some clients may need you to be proactive to further clarify the message for the individual with LEP, and may also need you to act as a cultural broker. You should, at all times, alert the client of the situation and ask beforehand if a proactive approach is needed, and whether it meets with the client’s approval. You are expected to keep the client abreast of the exchange with the individual who has LEP, at all times, whenever helpfulness is called for. In any event, you should not take sides and should remain impartial throughout the entire interpreting session, as per the Interpreter Code of Ethics.

You must listen attentively at all times throughout the call and not allow yourself to be distracted by anything other than the call itself.

If the client makes a comment, either positive or negative, that requires attention from the company, you should acknowledge the comment and direct the client to the Customer Service Department number (1-800-752-6096, option 2), or you may submit a Support Request.

2.5 Maintain a Quiet Working Environment

You are expected to secure a quiet work environment while interpreting. As such, it is unacceptable to have babies crying, children speaking loudly, or dogs barking in the work-at-home background; it is equally unacceptable to have music or any other loud noise in the background. You are also expected to avoid distractions while interpreting, which is why you should not have loud or side conversations, carry out household chores, tend to children or take other calls on cellular phones while interpreting. All cellular phones must be turned off while you are interpreting. Please note that any non-adherence to these guidelines as observed by your SLS and/or shared by the client, via Voice of the Customer (VOC) feedback, has the potential of impacting your performance history and status.

2.6 Close the Call Appropriately

You should interpret the client's closing remarks completely. For example, if the client says, *"Thank you for choosing XYZ company"*, or *"Is there anything else I can help you with, Mr. Sánchez?"* the message must be rendered in its entirety to the individual with LEP, including their name. If the individual with LEP expresses appreciation to you for your interpretation, you may acknowledge the appreciation briefly and pass the thank-you on to the client as well.

The closing of the call should leave the client with a positive impression of the services you have provided. In order to accomplish this, you need to remember to wait for the client to initiate the closing of the call and then proceed to close the call by offering additional assistance (See * below).

It is unacceptable to end a call simply because you are nearing the end of your shift, or approaching the beginning of a break. You are expected to remain on the call for its duration. Please plan ahead for any personal commitments you may have near the end of your shift.

As a rule, you should wait for the client to disconnect before you drop the call. However, you should proceed to disconnect if you know that the call has come to an end and you are no longer needed. This can be done, for example, when the client says: *"That's all, interpreter,"* *"Thank you, interpreter. I will transfer the call to another department and they will call your company back."*

*When closing the call, you should offer additional assistance by employing one of the phrases below:

- a) *"Is there anything else I can help you with, Doctor Salas?"* or,
- b) *"May I be of any further assistance, Ms. Amaya?"* or,
- c) *"Will that be all for the interpreter, Doctor Mata?"*

You should then thank the client/provider by using any of the phrases below:

- a) *"Thank you for using our services"* or
- b) *"We appreciate your business"* or,
- c) *"Thank you for allowing us to help you with your interpretation needs today, Dr. Coll"*

An example of the flow to follow upon closing the call is as follows:

Interpreter: *"Is there anything else I can help you with, Doctor King?"*

Client: *"No, that's it. Thank you, Interpreter."*

Interpreter: *"Thank you for using our services."*

NOTE: Due to the sensitive nature of medical/clinical calls, we ask that for these types of calls, you adhere to the use of, *"Thank you for using our services,"* instead of, *"Thank you for your business."*

Please refrain from employing the following informal phrases when closing the call: *"You got it!"* *"Sure thing!"* *"You bet!"* *"Bye now!"* *"Hey, any time!"* Remember that you should close your calls as professionally as you initiate them. The last remark you make to the client will have the greatest impact on your ability to leave a positive or negative impression on the client, regardless of the quality of work you did throughout the call.

3. Interpretation Skills and Role

In order to render the highest level of quality interpretation, you must make every effort to put into practice all of the skills mentioned in this section. It is also important that you be efficient and conscious of the length of each call, maintain total concentration throughout the call and develop good note-taking skills to reduce the need for excessive requests for verification and repetition. In addition, you should adhere to the need to remain within your specific role throughout each interpreting session.

3.1 Offer Accurate and Complete Renditions

As cited in the Code of Ethics, you must be faithful to the source language and its register, maintain the highest degree of accuracy, and offer a complete rendition free of summarizing, editorializing, omissions or additions. Remaining faithful to the source language does not imply that you should render a verbatim interpretation. Each language has its idiosyncrasies in terms of syntax and semantics; thus, a concept that can be expressed by one word in one language may require a full sentence in another language. At times the equivalent of a term may require a full explanation in many languages, since a direct equivalent for the word may not exist. Likewise, idiomatic expressions and jargon cannot be interpreted verbatim. Interpreting idioms word for word will not make any sense at all to native speakers of many languages. Think of an idiom such as, “*Don’t look a gift horse in the mouth*”; how would you render this idiom to the individual with LEP to ensure it makes sense to them? Is there a verbatim equivalent in the target language? Or is the equivalent in your language more around saying, “*a gifted horse should not have his canine teeth looked at*”? Remaining faithful to the source language must be understood as remaining faithful to the concept, the meaning, the register and the message the speaker is intending to convey. This is why you must ensure that you continue studying industry terminology, regionalisms, and idiomatic expressions.

3.1.1 Accuracy with Numbers

It is important to be extremely accurate with numbers. Accuracy with numerical data is critical. The types of information that often need to be verified include, but are not limited to, the dosage and frequency of medications, credit card numbers, social security numbers, phone numbers, addresses, account balances, etc. Please bear in mind that excessive verifications affect the call flow, so it is important to be attentive and to have a good note-taking technique in place.

3.1.2 Preserve the Original Tone

To ensure accuracy, the tone used when interpreting should reflect the original tone used in the source language. When the client wants to convey urgency or firmness to the individual with LEP, you should adjust your tone accordingly. By the same token, if a doctor uses a sincere or caring tone when speaking to a terminally ill patient, you should convey that caring tone as well. If you were in a foreign country and you did not speak the local language and fell ill while visiting and needed an interpreter yourself, how would you want to be treated as a patient with Limited English Proficiency? Would you want that interpreter to be empathetic and compassionate toward you?

On all calls, it is important to convey the utmost courtesy and patience to facilitate communication. You should use your best judgment so that your speech does not reflect impatient or angry tones from the client or individual who has LEP to such an extent that courtesy is compromised. It is important to understand that mimicking the client or the individual with LEP is not appropriate or professional, and is considered unacceptable.

3.1.3 Maintain Register

You should interpret into the target language maintaining the same register that was used in the source language. This is particularly important on calls of a legal or medical nature. Register refers to the level of formality of language used. For instance, the phrase “acid reflux” is a higher register term for “heartburn.” Another example would be “ophthalmologist;” a lower register way to express this term is “eye doctor.”

When a linguistic equivalent is lacking, you should define the term as closely as possible. For instance, if no term for “deductible” exists in the target language, a definition of “payment out of your own pocket” could be used.

In some medical settings, you may have to ask the provider to rephrase the statement or question, once it is evident that the individual with LEP has not understood the higher register term used by the provider. You should not assume that the individual with LEP has not understood, but should offer instead to clarify whether the message has been understood. Thus, you may ask, “*Dr. Milnes,*

for the sake of accuracy, may the interpreter confirm whether or not the patient has understood what the Whipple procedure is?”

NOTE: Calls of a legal nature (court calls) allow no room for changing the register. You must refrain from changing register at all times on court calls.

On calls of a customer service nature, where expediency may be the main priority of the client, it may become less important to respect the register of the source language than to select a rendition in the target language that will be best understood by the individual with LEP. The interpreter should use the higher register term first and then proceed to lower the register once it is clear that the individual with LEP does not understand the high register term.

3.1.4 Demonstrate Knowledge of Industry Terminology

You must maintain the highest degree of accuracy at all times, especially when rendering industry-specific terminology. This is particularly important when interpreting for medical, legal, insurance, financial and technical calls, as these industries have highly specialized terminology that must be precisely interpreted to ensure a positive outcome of the call. As a professional interpreter, it is incumbent upon you to be resourceful and familiarize yourself with the necessary industry-specific terminology.

- **Responding to Challenges to Interpreting**

If you are challenged regarding the use of a certain term, you may politely respond with any of the following phrases, as applicable: *“The interpreter stands by the rendition,” “The interpreter will gladly repeat the question,” “The interpreter apologizes and wishes to restate the rendition,” “The interpreter wishes to make a correction,” “With your permission, the interpreter wishes to further clarify this point.”*

- **Handling Unfamiliar Terminology**

In scenarios where you are not familiar with the terminology used on a call, you should do your best to resolve each issue through clarification.

If the terminology being used is so complex that accuracy may be compromised, you should be resourceful and seek the client’s permission to diligently consult reference materials, such as dictionaries, glossaries, etc. Do not, however, place the client on hold to inquire about a term. Again, you should be resourceful and diligent.

If you lack the special skills necessary to deliver the information without compromising accuracy, you should disqualify yourself from the call, with the client’s permission, and offer to request another interpreter for the client. For example:

“To ensure the best quality, please allow me to connect you to an interpreter specialized in _____ (finance, insurance, court, medical, or technical field).”

It is important to avoid confusion between **specialized** and **certified**. There are calls from certain clients that usually are of a customer-service nature and may develop into more complex calls, thus requiring an interpreter who is specialized in certain fields. Some medical calls may involve setting up appointments, in which case, L3, L4 and L5 interpreters are **qualified** to handle these calls. On occasion, however, the call can become a challenging and complex clinical call and, in that case, the L3 interpreter may need to disqualify themselves from the call so that a specialized interpreter in the medical field (L4) can handle the call.

It is important to note that you should continuously enhance your skills by compiling your own glossaries, in addition to using those provided by LLS.

3.1.5 Client Requests Regarding Written Materials

If the client asks you to use a document previously provided to the interpreters by LLS, you should use it as a reference tool to familiarize yourself with its content. For some special clients, however, you will have to proceed to read the script as indicated by the Training Department, once the client instructs you to proceed with the script. You must have the scripts readily available at all times, keeping the updated versions organized and easily accessible. On some calls, questions may need to be read to the individual with LEP directly by you. You will then relay the answers to the client and wait for further instructions from the client about how to proceed.

It is unacceptable to not have scripts available for those clients who have specifically requested that the script be used during the interpreting session.

3.1.6 Voices Heard in Background

In situations where you can hear the individual with LEP addressing someone else in the background, you must alert the client and proceed to interpret what is being said, as applicable. Some specific situations where you are required to interpret background voices, pursuant to the law, are:

- In the case of a threat of bodily injury or death
- In the case of child or elder abuse

In other situations of lesser gravity, you should say, *“Excuse me, this is the interpreter speaking, there is another person providing the answers for your client in the background, Mr. Lawson.”* Wait for instructions from the client on how to proceed.

3.1.7 Abbreviations and Acronyms

If possible, you should use an equivalent abbreviation or acronym in the target language. If you are not familiar with an abbreviation or acronym in the target language, or if an exact equivalent does not exist, you have two options: you can interpret the words that the letters stand for in the source language, or request a clarification from the client if you do not understand what the abbreviation stands for. If the client does not know what the letters stand for, you should request that the client provide the meaning of the entire abbreviation or acronym to interpret it in an expanded fashion as accurately as possible. If the individual with LEP is repeatedly using the abbreviation or acronym in English, you can use the same abbreviation or acronym that the individual with LEP is using in order to facilitate the communication.

3.1.8 Proper Names

Proper names, such as company names, brand names, etc., should not be interpreted into the target language unless they are commonly accepted equivalents. This also applies to street names, and directions included in a street name, such as north, east, etc.

3.1.9 Offensive Language

When offensive language is used by the individual with LEP, you must communicate this to the client. For customer service types of calls, it is appropriate to alert the client and seek his or her lead as to whether or not the offensive remarks should be interpreted. This is true even if the individual with LEP specifically requests that you not interpret what was stated. You may say, for example, *“This is the interpreter speaking; the gentleman is using offensive language; would you like me to interpret that?”* If the client specifically tells you not to interpret the offensive remarks, you should defer to the client's instruction. **For legal calls, however, you should always interpret the offensive language, precisely as stated.**

3.1.10 Request Clarification Appropriately and When Necessary

- **Clarifying Appropriately**

You should seek the client's permission before obtaining clarification from the individual with LEP. An example of an appropriate way to ask for clarification is, *"This is the interpreter. I'm sorry, but Ms. Zhao used a term that has multiple meanings. May I ask for clarification, please?"*

For calls of a customer service nature, if it is in the interest of maintaining the call flow, you may request very minor clarifications directly from the individual with LEP, including, but not limited to, verification of dates or numbers, or repetitions for the pronunciation and spelling of proper names, and then proceed to advise the client of what took place in the exchange with the individual with LEP. You should make such clarifications very sparingly to avoid running the risk of appearing to the client that you have stepped out of the interpreter's role by taking over the call.

You should refer to yourself in the third person when making a clarification. Some examples of how to request a clarification are, *"This is the interpreter speaking"*, *"The interpreter respectfully requests a repetition of the last three words,"* or *"Could the interpreter ask Mr. Carroll to repeat his last response?"* However, it is recommended that interpreters avoid the excessive use of *"This is the interpreter,"* since unwarranted repetition of that phrase throughout the call can impact the flow of the call.

- **Clarifying When Necessary**

In order to maintain the highest degree of accuracy, you should clarify whenever the individual with LEP, or the client, uses a term or phrase with which you are unfamiliar.

- **Clarifying the Individual's with LEP Pronunciation of Proper Names in English**

When the individual with LEP mentions an English proper name in a way that makes it difficult for you to understand, you should provide a phonetic rendition of the word, and alert the client if further clarification (such as spelling or repetition) is needed. For example, *"This is the interpreter speaking, I would need to confirm if the street name shared by Ms. Herrera is 'Taylor' or 'Tyler' Street."*

- **Clarifying Due to Cultural Barriers to Communication**

When a unique cultural practice is hindering communication, you may, with the permission of the client, provide a cultural framework to facilitate understanding. For example, the individual with LEP might mention both the paternal and maternal last names, causing confusion for the client. You may then interject with the following phrase, *"This is the interpreter speaking; if I may, in some cultures it is common to use both the paternal and maternal last names."*

- **Clarifying Due to Audibility Problems**

If you are unable to clearly hear what is being said by the client or the individual with LEP due to such factors as background noise, speakerphones, static or a bad connection, you should always **apologize to the client and alert them** to the source of the problem. You should follow the client's lead as to how to proceed. If the client does not know how to proceed, you may provide assistance by offering a suggestion. For example, *"May the interpreter ask Mr. Mendoza to raise his voice volume so that the interpreter can hear him better?"*

Likewise, if the individual with LEP cannot hear you, you should address the client by saying, *"This is the interpreter. I'd like to inform you that I will have to speak louder as Mr. Lizardo cannot hear me"*, or *"Let me try to raise the volume on my phone as Mr. Frias*

cannot hear me.” Sometimes adjusting the volume, or simply repeating the statement will help. What is important is that the client understands that you are doing your best to interpret the call, despite the audibility problems.

- **Clarifying Due to Difficulty Understanding the Client’s Accent**

If you are unable to understand the client due to a particular pronunciation issue, you should politely apologize and request that the information be repeated, or be repeated at a slower pace, without mentioning the source of the problem, so as to not be perceived discourteous. It is inappropriate and unacceptable to tell the client that their English cannot be understood.

3.2 Demonstrate Good Command of Both Source and Target Languages

You should have a good command of your working languages to ensure that you are easily understood by all parties on the line. Although your speech may be accented, knowledge of correct grammar, syntax and general vocabulary must be demonstrated at all times during an interpreting session. It is also important to learn and understand regionalisms, slang and idioms, as well as high register terms, so that you can interpret effectively for all customers.

Additionally, you should express yourself with clarity by carefully pronouncing and enunciating every word spoken in both languages in order to be understood. Examples of inappropriate utterances include habitual mumbling, stuttering, and use of filler words, such as “*um,*” “*uh,*” “*well,*” “*like,*” “*you know,*” etc.

3.3 Manage the Flow of the Call

You should conform, and adapt, to the pace of the call while maintaining accuracy, as required. An essential aspect of managing the flow of the call is to keep the client informed about what is transpiring at all times. You should let the client know of any of the following situations, which include, but are not limited to, a bad connection, not being able to hear the individual with LEP, requesting a repetition from the individual with LEP, or clarifying questions, etc. The client should never have to interrupt you to ask questions, such as “*Interpreter, what is happening?*” or “*Interpreter, what did he say?*”

By keeping the client informed, you ensure a smooth flow of information back and forth between the client and individual with LEP. This can be achieved by obtaining workable segments, avoiding interpreting while others are speaking, offering timely renditions, and keeping requests for repetitions to a minimum.

3.3.1 Obtain Workable Segments from the Client and the Individual with LEP

Information needs to be obtained in appropriate segments so that you can provide a complete and accurate rendition. The length of the segments obtained may depend on your retention capability or your note-taking skills. When the client or the individual with LEP has given a sufficient amount of information for you to interpret, yet continues to talk, you should, in a courteous and professional manner, request that information be given in workable segments prior to proceeding with your rendition. For example, “*Darwin, this is the interpreter speaking, to ensure accuracy, I would appreciate it if you could give me the information in smaller/shorter segments.*”

You may request a partial repetition if the information was not retained in its entirety. If the client or individual with LEP continues to give lengthy segments, you may say, for example, “*I’m sorry to interrupt you, Laura: to ensure accuracy, I would appreciate if you could give me the information in smaller/shorter segments*” or, “*Agata, could you please repeat the last sentence of the discharge instructions?*” or, in a court setting, “*The interpreter wishes to address the court: the interpreter requests shorter segments.*”

3.3.2 Avoid Interpreting While Others Are Speaking

It is unacceptable to begin interpreting while the client or individual with LEP is still speaking. You should first make sure the individual with LEP or client has stopped speaking before providing your

rendition. Should the information become unmanageable, you should respectfully ask the party to pause so you may interpret their message.

3.3.3 Provide a Timely Rendition

You should always be expedient and begin interpreting in a timely manner, i.e., after hearing the message and before it gets too long to manage. An indication that your rendition is not timely is when the individual with LEP jumps in to answer the question directly in broken English, or the client becomes impatient. Unnecessary pauses or untimely renditions can affect expediency and the flow of the call, causing the client to become unhappy. Conversely, interrupting the flow of the call by jumping in, speaking too quickly, or cutting off the speaker can affect the flow as well. Please remember that you may need to wait until a complete idea has been expressed by the client before you start interpreting.

If the client prefers to provide background information or instructions between utterances, you should follow such directions, and proceed to interpret the information at the appropriate time.

3.4 Avoid Taking over the Call

You should never lose sight of the fact that your role is to remove the obstacle created by the language barrier and not to assume responsibility for the call. The role of conduit, which is the default role of the interpreter, is the least invasive role and should be used for most interpreting sessions. The other roles that you assume as an interpreter are those of clarifier and cultural broker, but these roles are only used temporarily (mostly in health care settings, and not usually in court settings) and should only be used as a last resort when there is a breakdown in communication between the client and the individual who has LEP. You must at all times provide renditions by following the client's and/or the lead of the individual with LEP. You must never initiate any questions nor elicit any responses on your own.

Should you need to switch from a conduit role to a clarifier role at any point on the call (to clear up a misunderstanding on the part of the individual with LEP, for example), you must let the client know what you are attempting to do. Clients appreciate being informed, especially when you explain that you are doing your best to ensure accurate communication in a timely and effective manner. **NOTE:** You may resort to using the role of clarifier for clarification purposes only, NOT for initiating questions. This is at times more accepted by clients on calls of a customer service nature. For the roles of the interpreter in other settings, please refer to industry-specific training material. Even for customer service calls, please follow the client's lead and keep the client informed at all times. **NOTE: The role of advocacy is not to be used during telephonic or video interpreting.**

3.4.1 Requests from Client for Interpreter to Take Over

If the client requests that you take the lead in initiating questions and/or giving explanations or responses to the individual with LEP, you should politely seek the client's guidance. For example, if the client says, *"Interpreter, go ahead and get his medical history,"* you may say, *"To make sure that I obtain the information you need, what are the specific questions you would like me to ask first?"* In customer service-oriented industry settings, such as banks, health insurance companies, utilities, etc., another approach would be to verify the client's request by asking (as appropriate):

"Would you like me to get their name and account number, Claudia?"

"Would you like me to start by obtaining their account information, Carla?"

"Do you need their date of birth and Social Security Number, Pamela?"

3.4.2 Requests From Client for Interpreter to Take Over in Emergency Situations

In general, 911 calls require that you take a more active role as the interpreter. If the client specifically requests that you take the lead in an emergency situation, you should choose a phrase to convey to the individual with LEP **only** what the client has instructed.

For example, if you are asked to calm down the individual with LEP, you may say to them, in language, *“Please stay calm.”* However, **you must not make any remarks of your own**, such as *“Help is on the way,” “Everything will be fine,”* etc. If the client says, *“Interpreter, keep her on the line,”* you may say repeatedly, *“Please stay on the line,”* or *“Don’t hang up.”*

3.4.3 Transferred by the Client

When you and the individual who has LEP are transferred to another department, you should provide an introduction, (if applicable), and add, *“This call may be monitored for Training and Quality Assurance purposes.”* You may also provide the name of the department the call was transferred from, if that is known to you. If you are aware of the nature of the call, you may provide a brief summary of those details. For example, *“Hello, my name is Kysha, a Spanish interpreter. I am proud to serve you. This call may be monitored for Training and Quality Assurance purposes. Mrs. Gamboa and I have been transferred to you from the Technical Support Department, and she would like to find out if her last payment has been received.”*

After this introduction, it is unacceptable for you to answer on behalf of the individual with LEP. You should not provide any other information previously obtained without the client’s lead, as this violates confidentiality of information previously shared. The client may at times have the capability of transferring the call with several parties on the line. When in doubt, a useful phrase may be, *“Certainly, I will advise Ms. Trinh that you will be transferring us. Is there a number I should provide her with in case we get disconnected, Monica?”*

3.4.4 Interpret Automated Instructions

When you and the individual with LEP are transferred to another department and you are connected to an automated system that is prompting information to be entered, you may either attempt to interpret the instructions (if the situation lends itself to doing so) or choose to stay on the line until a representative comes on the line. When an automated response system is involved, you should use your best judgment in assisting the individual with LEP to respond to the prompts. You should keep the following factors in mind: length of time allotted for responding to the prompts and the individual’s understanding of the prompts. Please use your best judgment.

3.5 Avoid Interacting with the Individual with LEP without the Client’s Permission

Interaction between you and the individual with LEP without the client’s permission should be avoided, except in the case of minor verifications, such as requests for repetitions, or the spelling of proper names. Any questions or comments initiated by the individual with LEP and directed to you must be interpreted to the client. Should the individual with LEP repeat the question to confirm what was said, you may very briefly respond and immediately advise the client that the individual with LEP was confirming or repeating information previously stated. By doing so, you are making it clear to the client that no side conversation is taking place between you and the individual with LEP.

3.5.1 Minimize Conversation with the Individual with LEP while on Hold

When the client puts both you and the individual with LEP on hold, you should politely discourage any conversation related to the content of the call; it is inappropriate to respond to any such questions from the individual with LEP. If the individual with LEP initiates such a conversation, it is appropriate for you to politely say, *“Just a moment, please, we’re on hold; if you don’t mind, could you ask this question when the nurse is back on the line?”* Please avoid saying, *“Sorry, but I’m not supposed to talk to you when the client is not on the line.”* If the individual with LEP asks (in language), *“Is anyone on the line?”* you are expected to acknowledge the question by saying, *“Yes, we’re still on hold. Please continue to wait, Ms. Salcido.”* It is unacceptable for you to provide no response when the individual with LEP asks if anyone is on the line as basic professional courtesy requires you to be responsive to any of our customers.

If the individual with LEP provides unsolicited information or asks a question while on hold, you should inform them that all information will be interpreted and then write the information down and relay it when the client comes back on the line; if questions are directed to you, you should respond in a professional manner. For example, if the individual with LEP asks, “*Where are you located?*” it is appropriate to say, “*I’m working from my home office,*” as long as your response does not cause the conversation to be unnecessarily prolonged.

3.6 Remain Impartial and Unbiased

3.6.1 Abstain from Giving Personal Opinions

You should not offer your opinion, make suggestions, or share points of view at any time during the course of interpreting, unless it is to clarify cultural differences or to correct misunderstandings, particularly in health care settings, and with the permission of the client.

- **Requests from Client for Interpreter’s Opinion**

If the client requests that you provide your opinion, you should politely explain that an opinion cannot be expressed by saying, “*I apologize, but as the interpreter, I can only interpret what is being said.*” For example, 1) Client: “*Interpreter, is this person drunk?*” Interpreter: “*I’m very sorry, but I’m unable to determine if the person is drunk; I can only tell you that their speech is slurred.*” 2) Client: “*Interpreter, do you think she understood?*” Interpreter: “*I would be more than happy to ask Ms. Majano if she understood;*” or, “*I apologize, but I am unable to ascertain whether Mr. Calvo understood...*”

- **Stating Only the Observable Facts**

Clients may try to verify their opinion of the individual with LEP with your assistance. You should not make any judgment calls, but only state the observable facts and/or offer to interpret the client’s questions directly to the individual with LEP for clarification.

For example, if the client asks, “*Interpreter, does he sound upset to you?*” you might respond by saying, “*His voice volume has risen, but I cannot determine if he’s upset. Would you like me to ask him, Laurent?*” or “*I can only tell you that he’s using foul language.*”

3.6.2 Remain Neutral and Impartial throughout the Call

Pursuant to the Code of Ethics, interpreters shall be impartial and unbiased and shall refrain from conduct that may give any appearance of bias. You shall not allow personal opinions to interfere with your duties, nor add unsolicited comments or make recommendations, except to assist with communication. For example, it is clearly unacceptable to offer your personal advice or recommendation about the quality or cost of one client's services over another's.

On calls of a sensitive nature, the interpreter shall avoid being judgmental as to the reason needed for the procedure; the reason may be due to a medical necessity; even in the event of a non-medical necessity, the interpreter must remain neutral and detached. Some examples of sensitive calls may include but are not limited to: Medical Assistance in Dying (Canada), Medical Aid in Dying (U.S.), pregnancy termination, vaccinations, gender-affirming related appointments/surgeries, suicidal ideation screening, and the like.

While on the line, the role of conduit, the primary role of a professional interpreter, becomes a priority. Once the interpreter is engaged for the session, the interpreter shall remain detached and act as a professional conduit only. Interpreter can request a Peer Support Program member to debrief after the call, if needed. The interpreter must remain detached regardless of personal/religious preferences; the interpreter should monitor themselves for personal biases to assure that these are not reflected while interpreting. As professional interpreters, we must ensure effective communication while building empathy and trust, and remaining compassionate.

3.7 Use Correct Protocol/Cultural Brokering

Many industries and individual clients have specific needs and requirements. The following guidelines address some of the needs unique to those industries or clients.

3.7.1 Use First Person Interpretation at All Times

You should use first person as the default mode of interpreting for all calls. The following are a few exceptions:

- **Following Client's Lead into Third Person**

If the client specifically requests that the call be interpreted in the third person, you may follow his or her lead. You should refrain, however, from using, "*he said/she said.*"

- **Interpreting Statements Directed to the Interpreter in First Person**

If the individual with LEP addresses you directly, you should continue to interpret exactly what is stated.

3.7.2 Exercise Good Judgment to Meet the Requirements of the Industry

Each industry has unique requirements that you must meet. Some of the unique requirements are as follows:

Customer Service Calls:

The highest standard of customer service is required on Customer Service calls that involve routine transactions or other matters and may not involve highly technical language. Examples of these types of calls are requests for utility services, renting a car, making an appointment, paying a bill, etc.

On some customer service calls, the client may instruct the interpreter that the call may be recorded or monitored for quality assurance purposes. The interpreter should render these instructions in compliance with privacy laws. The fact that the call may be recorded does not imply the call is of a legal nature. If you are a L3 interpreter, this scenario does not merit that you disqualify yourself from the call. You should, therefore, proceed with the call, as usual.

- **Verification and Clarification**

In the interest of expediency and client satisfaction, you may request minor clarifications directly from the individual with LEP, but only to verify numbers and to request repetitions in the pronunciation and/or spelling of proper names, and then immediately advise the client of the exchange.

- **Register**

On calls of a customer service nature, where expediency is sometimes in the best interest of the client, it may be less important to respect the register of the source language than to select a rendition that will be understood by the individual with LEP in the target language. For instance, if a slightly higher register phrase is not understood, such as, "*\$25 will be credited to your account,*" then you could say, "*\$25 will be added back to your account.*"

- **Expediency**

It is important to facilitate the call so that the information shared is clear and promptly rendered. To facilitate the call is to be helpful and ensure that both parties communicate effectively across the linguistic and cultural barriers. Oftentimes, the client may not entirely understand what the individual with LEP is stating, even though you may have relayed the exact information.

When this happens, you should offer to repeat the information and/or rephrase the question to ensure that the message gets across. You should make communication easier for the two parties on the line in the interest of expediency and efficiency. An example of expediency is when the individual with LEP replies to the question posed with a “What?” When this happens, you should advise the client that the question/statement will be repeated for the individual with LEP, instead of going back to the client with “What?”

- **Keeping the client informed**

When you verify or clarify directly with the individual with LEP, or request a repetition, it is crucial that the client be informed of your exchange with the individual with LEP. e.g., “*The interpreter repeated the question and this is what Mr. Jimenez has replied...*”, or “*The interpreter requested the address and did verify with Ms. Katty whether it was a house or an apartment.*”

911 Calls (or any other emergency calls):

Quick Pace

On a 911 call, especially when there is a true emergency, you should keep up with the quick pace while obtaining information. If necessary, you may step in to direct the individual with LEP to immediately provide the necessary information to the dispatcher or Public-Safety Answering Point (PSAP).

- **Opening**

As soon as possible, and if applicable, quickly provide the PSAP with your first name, language and ID number, always giving first priority to the PSAP’S need to interrupt you, if necessary, to obtain crucial emergency information. If no specific instructions can be clearly heard from the PSAP in the midst of all the yelling that may be involved, please proceed to ask the individual with LEP, “What is the emergency?” **NOTE: Do NOT state “This call may be monitored for Training and Quality Assurance purposes” on 911 calls.**

- **Prioritizing Information**

In a life or death emergency, you should obtain the critical information (location, nature of the emergency) and render what is stated in a prompt and concise manner. Secondary details should be obtained and interpreted to the PSAP after the essential information is provided whenever possible so as not to miss any information. Essential information includes, whether or not it is an emergency, the exact nature of the emergency, its location, and whether or not an ambulance is needed.

- **Update Dispatcher/PSAP Frequently**

You must keep the PSAP updated frequently, especially if the caller is not coherent, is providing too much information at a time, or you cannot hear the caller clearly.

- **Verification of Numbers and Addresses**

It is imperative that you verify street addresses and/or locations on emergency calls at all times to ensure that help is sent to the right location.

- **Verification of Proper Names**

When verifying a proper name, such as that of a street, city, or place of business, you should, whenever possible and to save time, first try to provide a phonetic rendition and then offer to get a spelling for the PSAP, if necessary. For some languages, it may be necessary to ask for a spelling in order to convey the proper name to the PSAP. You should rely on your language expertise to render the information accurately.

- **Controlling Segment Length**

If the individual with LEP has given you the answer to a specific question asked by the PSAP, but continues to ramble on, you should gently, but firmly, ask the individual with LEP to pause, and relay the information to the PSAP immediately.

- **Listening for Clues to True Emergencies**

You should listen for key words that indicate life-threatening situations, such as “choking”, “convulsion”, “heart problems”, “problems breathing”, “unconscious”, “bleeding”, “turning blue”, etc. **Be attentive to any mention of presence of guns, knives or other weapons.**

- **Professionalism: polite forms/tone of voice**

The use of polite forms of expression is expected on 911 calls. The need for expediency and a quick pace does not overshadow the importance of the use of courteous forms of expression, polite forms of address and/or the use of a respectful, caring and professional tone of voice, as well as empathy toward the individual with LEP. NOTE: Please note 911 calls are recorded by the client.

Clinical Calls:

As per national health care interpreting standards and client requirements, the greeting to the patient with Limited English Proficiency needs to include an announcement of confidentiality and completeness in interpretation. This means that on clinical calls that involve a patient and a health care provider, health care interpreting standards established in the United States specifically require the interpreter to state that all information shared during the course of the call will be kept strictly confidential, and that everything spoken by either party will be interpreted.

Please follow the protocol illustrated to open the call when a health-care provider and a patient are on the line: Identify yourself as the interpreter by providing your first name, ID# and language, and then add, “*I am proud to serve you. This call may be monitored for Training and Quality Assurance purposes.*” Since some clinical calls may take place with both parties on-site, we may ask if the patient is with the provider. For example: “*Thank you for calling. This is Marli, Interpreter ID 555555, for Spanish. I am proud to serve you. This call may be monitored for Training and Quality Assurance purposes. Is your patient with you or do you need me to call them for you?*” If the patient is on the line, address the provider with “*I am ready for your instructions.*” If the patient is not on the line, say, “*I am happy to call them for you. May I have the phone number, starting with the area code? If there is a voicemail, would you like me to leave a message?*”

Upon hearing the provider’s instructions, and as soon as you begin to address the patient with LEP, please use the following greeting in language: “*Hello, Ms. Marín (if patient’s last name is not known, use the most appropriate and respectful form of address for your culture). I will be the interpreter for you on this call. I am proud to serve you. This call may be monitored for Training and Quality Assurance purposes. Everything you say will be kept strictly confidential and I will interpret everything you say to your doctor.*”

The following is another example of a proper opening on a clinical call:

Interpreter: “*Thank you for calling. This is Yvette, Interpreter ID 555555, for Spanish. I am proud to serve you. This call may be monitored for Training and Quality Assurance purposes. Is your patient with you or do you need me to call them for you?*”

Client: “*No, thanks. Mrs. Chen is on the line. I am Dr. Reizek.*”

Interpreter: “*Thank you. I am ready for your instructions.*”

Client: “*Mrs. Chen, I have the results of your biopsy.*”

Interpreter (in language): “*Hello, Mrs. Chen. This is the interpreter for you and Dr. Reizek is on the line. I am proud to serve you. This call may be monitored for Training and Quality*

Assurance purposes. I will interpret everything you say and everything you say will be kept strictly confidential. I have the results of your biopsy.”

- **Utmost Accuracy and Completeness**

You must take great care to interpret numerical information accurately in a medical setting. The following information must be verified: amounts and dosages of medications, temperatures, blood sugar readings, etc. You must interpret everything completely, including all hesitations and interjections, and everything else stated by either party.

- **Awareness of the Need for Cultural Clarifications**

You should be more alert to the potential need for cultural clarifications on clinical calls. For instance, some cultures have practices that need to be explained to the health-care provider to avoid misunderstandings or misperceptions. The form of address, or greeting, toward the patient with LEP, for example, may be different for certain cultures. Please follow relevant best practices for the given culture to ensure you are delivering the highest degree of respect. A caring tone should be used at all times to reflect the overall tone of the assessment taking place.

- **Passing the Phone Back and Forth**

When the client and patient with LEP pass the phone back and forth, it may be necessary for you to indicate to the patient with LEP when they need to hand the phone back to the client to expedite the communication. For example, *“Please pass the phone to the doctor, Mrs. Guzmán.”* It is recommended that you ask the client at the beginning of the call whether the phone will be passed to the patient with LEP.

- **Hospital Operator**

If you provide the greeting to the client and then realize that the call has been transferred by the hospital operator, you should be ready to provide the full greeting again to the medical provider when they come on the line.

- **When the Individual with LEP Requests Information Not Be Disclosed**

When possible, you must try to avoid having the individual with LEP share information with you that they do not want to be disclosed to the client.

For example, if the individual with LEP says (in language), *“Don’t tell the doctor this, but...”* you need to politely interrupt them quickly and request permission from the client to explain to the individual with LEP that everything stated must be interpreted. If the individual with LEP insists that the information not be shared, then the interpreter should respect the individual’s wishes and inform the client that such a request has been made.

Court Calls:

NOTE: Do NOT state “This call may be monitored for Training and Quality Assurance purposes” on Court calls.

- **Utmost Accuracy**

You should interpret legal and court calls with the highest degree of accuracy, including all pauses and interjections. This includes anything the individual with LEP requests that you not interpret, as well as anything the individual with LEP states in English, but may not include conversations between an attorney and the individual with LEP or other court personnel, if so requested by the judicial parties involved. You should refrain from adding customer service phrases to the rendition; you should, however, use a professional tone and always be polite and courteous.

Additionally, you should always match the register of the source language as much as possible when interpreting for court and legal calls.

- **Refrain from Providing Cultural Clarifications and Explanations**

For legal calls, you should refrain from providing explanations and clarifications involving any cultural brokering, unless requested to do so by the client.

- **Handling Lack of Opportunity to Interpret**

When there is no pause allowing you to interpret (conversations between the judge and an attorney, clerk, bailiff or other party in the courtroom), you must alert the judge to this by saying, *“This is the interpreter speaking, Your Honor. The interpreter did not have an opportunity to interpret the statement(s) just made. How would you like the interpreter to proceed?”*

- **Providing Name and Address to Judge (or any client)**

On court calls, the judge may require you to provide your full name and address. When this happens, **you should provide your full name**; the address to be shared should be the LanguageLine Solutions’ address; i.e., 1 Lower Ragsdale Drive, Bldg. 2, Monterey, CA, 93940.

- **Providing Interpreter’s Qualifications**

When a judge asks to *voir dire* you regarding your qualifications, you should briefly share any of the following: any internal and/or external certifications you may have, any related formal training or experience you have, your education, and the length of time you have been interpreting.

If you have no previous court interpreting experience or certification, you may respond by saying, *“I have been tested and trained by my company in interpreting skills, and I will be happy to do my best to assist you in this matter.”* If a judge decides not to use you as the interpreter, you should thank the judge and hang up after the judge has done so. You also need to submit a Report Call Problem as soon as possible.

Finance Calls:

- **Verbatim Disclosures on Finance Calls:**

In our ongoing effort to be in compliance with federal and state laws that our banking clients are bound by, and to be consistent with all legal requirements, all standard disclosures read to consumers should be interpreted accurately and verbatim. Although our clients may share disclosures with us, it is important to keep in mind that the disclosures made available to you are to be used as reference only, which is why we recommend that you not read directly from the disclosure; you should pay close attention instead to what is being read to you, as disclosures can be revised by the clients at any time. To ensure the verbatim rendition of the legal disclosure, you should be diligent while taking notes, requesting repetitions (as needed), and obtaining short segments.

3.7.3 When Client or Individual with LEP Takes the Initiative to Communicate In Language

When you perceive that the client or individual with LEP have understood what was said in the other language, you may follow their lead. If one party tells you that they understood, you should convey this to the other party. If the party does not say anything to you, but rather responds directly without waiting for the utterance to be interpreted, you should pause and wait for the next question; if the conversation between the individual with LEP and the client carries on in English, you should then immediately verify with the client if you need to remain on the line.

If you are asked to stand by to assist and any misunderstanding takes place, you should alert the client to the nature of the misunderstanding and politely offer to interpret the information for them in order to clarify the situation. You may politely interject and say, for example, “*Dr. Garnier, would you like the interpreter to ask Mrs. Zhou to respond in Mandarin only and allow me to interpret her answers into English?*” If the individual with LEP makes an effort to speak in English and the pronunciation is unclear, you may ask the client if they would like the information repeated.

Once it appears that the communication between the two parties is effectively taking place, you should interject by asking whether you need to stay on the line, and proceed according to the client’s instructions.

The following are some suggestions of ways to ask the client whether it is necessary for you to remain on the line:

“This is the interpreter, Shantell. I just wanted to let you know that I am standing by and ready to assist should there be a need.”

“Would you like the interpreter to stay on the line in case any clarification is needed?”

“Excuse me, this is (interpreter’s name). It seems like Mrs. Armas can understand English. Would you like me to stay on the line as a back-up, or would you prefer that I disconnect?”

Should the client ask you to remain on the line, you are expected to listen attentively and take notes in case clarification is needed or a breakdown in communication occurs.

3.7.4 When the interpreter’s services are no longer needed

The interpreter should take the initiative to confirm with the client when the interpreter is no longer needed on the line. E.g. “*Mr. Cordon, would you like the interpreter to disconnect, or would you prefer that the interpreter stay on as back-up?*”

NOTE: It is unacceptable to quietly remain on the line without checking with the client as to whether you should stand by or disconnect. Doing so is grounds for disciplinary actions.

3.7.5 Maintain Confidentiality

As stated in the Code of Ethics, LanguageLine Solutions Interpreters shall respect all confidences received in the course of interpreting. All information obtained by you in the course of your professional duties shall remain strictly confidential. This information shall not be communicated, published or in any way divulged to any organization or person, other than the organization or person engaging the services of the interpreter. Notes taken during interpretation must be shredded or destroyed in such a manner that the notes would be unusable, unreadable or indecipherable. Simply placing the notes in a garbage can or recycling bin is not sufficient. Do not take notes on any electronic devices not approved by LanguageLine Solutions. Only take notes on paper that can be shredded at the end of the shift.

4. Unusual Circumstances

Many unforeseen situations that remain outside the scope of these guidelines may occur during a call, either because they are of a strictly procedural or administrative nature, or because they find their direct basis for action in other LanguageLine Solutions documents. Below are some directives about how to handle some of the more common situations.

4.1 Disconnected Calls

When any disconnection occurs during a call, you should submit a detailed Report Call Problem.

4.2 When the Individual with LEP is the Only Party on the Line

In situations where a disconnection occurs and the client is no longer on the line, you should direct the individual with LEP to call the client back. Do not place the dial-out for the individual with LEP.

4.3 Wrong Language or Dialect

When the language of the individual with LEP does not match the language (s) you are authorized by LLS to interpret, you should assist the client by saying, *“I’m sorry, your client speaks _____ (state the language); please hold for a minute while I find the appropriate interpreter for you.”* You should then transfer the call back to the Customer Agent (CA). You may release the call after providing the requested language information. If you cannot determine the language the individual with LEP is speaking, you should assist the client by saying *“I’m sorry, I am a _____ language) interpreter and I cannot determine the language your client speaks. Please hold for a minute while we find you the appropriate interpreter,”* and transfer the call back to a CA.

4.4 Interpreter Emergencies

If an emergency (severe illness, natural disaster, et al) occurs during a call, you must inform the client as follows: *“At this time, I must respectfully excuse myself due to an emergency situation. I apologize for the inconvenience.”* If, based on your emergency, you cannot transfer the call to a CA, as a last resort, you may ask the client to call back and request another interpreter. You should report the situation via a Report Call Problem as soon as you are able to do so.

4.5 Disqualification from a Call/Declining a Call

LanguageLine Solutions interpreters should make every effort to complete each call, even when difficult terminology is involved. The only exception is when L3 interpreters receive misdirected calls for which they are not qualified to interpret.

Should a situation arise where the quality of your performance is compromised, you may disqualify yourself, as per the Code of Ethics. An appropriate way of phrasing this would be, *“To ensure the best quality, I will transfer you to an interpreter who is specialized in _____ (finance, insurance, court, medical, or technical) field. I apologize for the inconvenience; thank you for your understanding.”* You must then follow up by submitting a Support Request.

4.6 Illegal Activity/Threat of Bodily Harm

In situations where an illegal activity (drug or human trafficking, bomb/death threats, etc.) is taking place and/or being openly discussed on a call, you are **required** to report the incident **immediately** to the company via the IHD, or via a Support Request. You must only report observable facts and refrain from making any assumptions about the alleged activity.

4.7 Lengthy Calls

In extenuating circumstances, such as with a very long call (**of over 2 hours**), when the level of concentration and accuracy is being compromised, you may resolve the situation by saying, *“In order to maintain the appropriate level of interpreting accuracy, the interpreter respectfully requests a short break at this time.”* If the client insists on continuing the call and you are exhausted, you may excuse yourself by saying, *“At this time I would like to respectfully excuse myself from this call since I can no longer concentrate sufficiently to provide you with the quality and professional level of interpreting required. I will transfer you to another interpreter who will gladly assist you.”* You should always wait for further instructions. If excused by the client, you should close by stating, *“Your patience and understanding are greatly appreciated”* or *“I appreciate your understanding, Dr. Medina.”* Please proceed to transfer by following system manual instructions respectively. A Report Call Problem should then be submitted.

American Sign Language (ASL) Interpreters: when the call has **direct and continuous conversation for 30 minutes or more**, where the interpreter risks physical injury, and due to the physical nature of ASL interpreting, it is acceptable for ASL interpreters to transfer a call before two hours if true fatigue has started

to affect the quality of the interpretation. Please be advised that abusing the use of the transfer feature will result in disciplinary actions. The following phrase should be said to the client when needing to transfer: *“Excuse me, Doctor Spradlin, in order to avoid repetitive motion injuries and to not compromise the quality of the interpretation, I will be transferring you to another interpreter who can provide you with an uncompromised level of service.”* You should place a warm transfer. **NOTE: You should always wait for further instructions from the client before transferring the call.**

Transfer based on specific gender request: additionally, you may transfer calls when there is a request for a different gender interpreter; i.e., you are a male interpreter and client/individual with LEP requests a female interpreter; or, you are a female interpreter and client/individual with LEP requests a male interpreter. Please follow the Transfer Call Function steps in the User manual.

4.8 Multiple Interpreting Events within the Same Call

In the event that a client asks you to interpret for several individuals with LEP consecutively, you may respond, *“I’ll be glad to help you with as many calls as I can accurately interpret, Maricruz. If I become too fatigued, I may request a short break, or I may ask that another interpreter take over. This will ensure that you receive the highest level of quality.”*

4.9 Wrong Company Name Used by Client

If the client refers to LanguageLine Solutions by any other name, you should refrain from correcting the client, since we do have different registered names. If you are asked to interpret something in which our company name is mentioned incorrectly, you do not need to correct the error but should rather interpret the client’s words as stated.

4.10 Question Regarding the Interpreter’s Location/Nationality

If the client asks, “Where are you located?” it is appropriate to give general information. For example, you may say, *“I’m working from my home office in the US,”* or *“I’m working from one of our call centers”* (if applicable). If the client or the individual with LEP asks you where you are from, you should use your best judgment to reply accordingly, *“I am originally from Gibraltar,”* for example. You should avoid ignoring the question, as that may be perceived as rude.

4.11 Interpreting Hold Messages

If the client places the individual with LEP and you on hold and the client’s hold music includes short messages for its customers, such as, *“Thank you for waiting; a representative will be with you shortly,”* you should interpret these words if there is an opportunity to do so. However, you do not need to interpret recorded advertisements or long messages.

4.12 Client’s Business-Related Questions

When you are asked questions related to areas of our business, such as billing, interpreter pay, etc., an appropriate answer would be, *“In order to ensure that you are provided with the most accurate information, I would be happy to transfer you the Customer Service Department, where they can answer all of your questions. Would you like me to share that number as well?”* If the client wants the number, provide 1-800-752-6096, option 2, or transfer the call to Customer Service.

4.13 Client’s Requests to Discuss Previous Calls

If the client requests that you provide details from your notes about the contents of a previous call, even if the call took place earlier that same day, please refer the client to the Customer Service Department.

4.14 Client’s Requests for Subpoenas

If you receive a call from an investigator, District Attorney, or defense lawyer who asks for specific information about a previously handled call, you should reply by saying, *“Please contact subpoenas@languageline.com for related requests.”* It is important that you not respond to any requests for

information without first escalating the request. Following this procedure will allow us to be consistent and provide the necessary support to all interpreters.

4.15 Client's Requests for Fax #/Email Address/Phone Number

If the client wishes to fax, or e-mail, a script or disclosure to you for your review, you may politely refer the client to the Training Department instead by saying, for example, *"All scripts would need to be sent to our Training Department for future distribution to the interpreters. For now, I will be happy to interpret for you as accurately as possible if you can read the script to me slowly and clearly, and in workable segments, please."* You should avoid sharing your contact information; i.e., cell phone number, home phone number, personal e-mail address, Rackspace email address, et al , with the client or the individual with LEP. There should be no follow-up email correspondence between you and the client, or you and the individual with LEP, as this would be a violation of the Code of Conduct.

4.16 Clients' Requests for Translation

If a client requests a written translation, you should refer them to the Translation Division. The client can send an email to translation@languageline.com or access www.llts.com for a quote or additional information. You should avoid sharing your e-mail address with the client.

4.17 Client's Requests for Interpretation of Written Material

If a client requests that you interpret certain written material or information, such as a medicine label, short instructions, etc., you are expected to help the client, as long as the text is of reasonable length and complexity. In such cases, the client or the individual with LEP will need to read the information to you.

4.18 Client's Requests for the Same Interpreter in the Future

If the client states that they will be requesting the same interpreter for future calls, an appropriate response would be, *"I will be happy to help you as long as I am available and not taking any other calls."*

4.19 Client's Requests for On-site Interpreter

If the client requests an on-site interpreter, you can refer the client to the Customer Service Department.

4.20 Client's Requests to Witness the Signing of a Consent Form

Upon having completed the interpreting session, you may proceed to provide your Interpreter ID # and name to the client should the client request that information; this would be used to document that the interpreting session took place and that you interpreted to the best of your ability. Should the client request additional information, such as your personal information, you should refer the client to the Customer Service Department.

If at any time you receive a call where the client requests your Interpreter ID without any interpretation having been provided by you, please advise the client that you are unable to provide your ID as you provided no interpreting services, apologize for the inconvenience, and refer the client to the Customer Service Department. You should also submit a Support Request.

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